Evnine on Magical Words

David Sanson
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The Magic Power of Language

> How are we to understand this alleged magic power of language? Should it be assimilated to physical power, illocutionary power, perlocutionary power, or is it a further, *sui generis* ("of its own kind") kind of power that language is believed to have? (215)

1. "None shall pass!"
2. "Outt go youre een (eyes), fordo (lit."undo, ruin") your syght."
3. "Let there be light!"

Magic as Illocution

4. "I have blessed you to YHWH," as ascribed on pottery.

> Blessings and curses are performative by their very nature, as the act of speaking or writing a blessing or a curse is what "activates" its power. (Mandell, as quoted by Evnine, 217)

Blessing as performative vs. blessing as actual conferral of benefits:

5. "Bless this house."
6. "This house is blessed by God."

Blessing is the actual bestowal of goods. Saying the words *causes* the bestowal of goods by "activating the power" of the words. So *saying it makes it so*, much like saying, "The meeting is adjourned" makes it so.

Objection:

> Not any utterance that makes itself true is a performative. ("I am now speaking" is not, for example.) For Austin, it is essential, in a performative, that the way in which uttering a sentence makes it true is conventional. Yet when Mandell says that "speaking or writing a blessing … is what 'activates' its power," she is implying that the way in which the utterance brings about its own truth (the actual conferral, according to the participants, of goods) is non-conventional. After all, how could people be made sick or well by mere convention in the way that they can be married by mere convention? This is precisely why we are dealing with magic here. Conventional power doesn't need "activating" in this sense. (218-19)

7. "I hereby make it the case that all swans are purple."

Is this the kind of action one can perform as an illocution? If not, is that a conceptual limitation, having to do with what an illocutionary act is, or is it a human limitation? What about when God says it?

Kropp on Transformatives

Transformative utterances

Utterances that make themselves true through extra-conventional, often causal processes rather than through the existence of conventions and institutions.

8. "I am now speaking."
9. "I am disturbing the air."

Objection:

> Speech act theory was developed by Austin to capture the ways in which language is an instrument of social and communicative action. The failure to attend to "magical contexts" wasn't just because they are weird and possibly disreputable. It was surely because they would depend on mechanisms that have nothing to do with the nature of language as a communicative and social tool, the original object of study. As we have seen, a class of transformatives could have been introduced without resort to magic, via simple examples like "I am now disturbing the air around me." The fact that cases like that were of no interest to Austin is evidence that he would not have seen the addition of transformatives to speech act theory as welcome. Transformativity should not be seen as a kind of illocutionary force at all. (220-21)

Spells that Use Performative Language

10. "And now I do release, discharge, and divorce you to be on your own, so that you are permitted and have authority over yourself to go and marry any man you desire."

This is a *get*, a Jewish formula for divorce. In uttering this to his wife in the right context, a man performs the illocutionary act of divorce. But it is also found inscribed on bowls, where it is part of a spell meant to banish demons from the home.

Is this an example of illocutionary magic?

> There is a kind of correspondence between a divorce and an exorcism. Each is a severing of a connection. But the kind of power needed for the severing is different in the two cases. In one, the connection is legal and it is severed by the use of performative language to change the legal situation. That is exactly the kind of work performatives are suited to. In the other, the connection is supernatural and must be severed by magic. Yet the language used is the same in both cases. (223)

Note that issue is that the **connection** is supernatural, not that it is a connection to a supernatural being. Nothing stops you from entering into a contract with the Devil. You can cajole, flatter, entreat, or threaten supernatural beings too. But, Evnine claims, you cannot *break a supernatural bond* as an illocutionary act.

Magic as Perlocution

> The sense in which saying something produces effects on other persons, or causes things, is a fundamentally different sense of cause from that used in physical causation by pressure, etc. It has to operate through the conventions of language and is a matter of influence exerted by one person on another. (Austin, as quoted by Evnine, 213)

Let S be a speaker, H a hearer, p a sentence, and φ and ψ action types. S's φ-ing H (to ψ) by uttering p is the performance of a perlocutionary act if and only if

(i) S performs an illocutionary act or propositional acts by uttering p.
(ii) S means by p what p means in the language of which it is a part.
(iii) H understands S to mean to perform some illocutionary act or propositional acts by uttering p.
(iv) H understands S to mean something by p.
(v) What H understands S to mean causes H to ψ or be φ-ed.

Argument: none of the cases fit these conditions.

Magic as Super-physical Power

> Linguistic magic can be divided into three major categories: the fiatic, the Orphic and the talismanic. The first category includes the creation of the signified by its signifier, the best example being the creation of the world by divine words. The Orphic category assumes the possibility of enchanting an already existing entity by means of vocal material. Last but not least is the talismanic, based on the drawing of energy by means of language, in order to use this energy for magical purposes. (Idel as quoted by Evnine, 228)

> Cases of fiatic magic present a special difficulty. Neither speech-act theory nor super-physical force is even superficially plausible as an explanation of the nature of the magic allegedly at work, the first because we are not dealing with sentences, the second because we are nonetheless dealing with meaning. [...] The magic must somehow be explained in terms of the power of the creator and an ontological difference between the creator and the created. The language is hardly necessary. And it may, in fact, be wondered why a being with "complete superiority" over something should have need of a linguistic utterance at all to bring that thing into existence. (229)

> Searle says that "when, e.g., God says 'Let there be light' that is a [supernatural] declaration" (1979, 18). If this is how things are supposed to work, the creation is tied not to any special power of the word "light," but to the fact that God's utterance is a declaration, taken together with the fact that God, unlike humans, is such that his declarations are effective not just for institutional reality but for all reality. This is quite a different understanding of linguistic magic from that associated with the special powers of words. And once again, we confront the puzzle of why God should need to say "let there be light" (or anything at all), in order to bring light into existence. This, in fact, is the problem at the heart of the notion of a transformative illocutionary force or a supernatural declaration. If the "way the world works" is such as to allow some entity to bring about a certain state of affairs, including the existence of something, there is no role for the declaration left to play. (230)

Magic as its own kind of Power

Necessary conditions for a successful account (232):

1) the power must take account of the linguistic meanings of magical utterances, whether of words or sentences;
2) it must produce real changes in the world, such as good or bad health, good or bad harvests, and so on (as opposed to conventional changes such as of legal status);
3) and it must produce those changes in non-anthropopathical (Leuba 1912, 350) and coervice (sic) (Versnel 1991, 92) ways.

Can these three conditions all be met together?